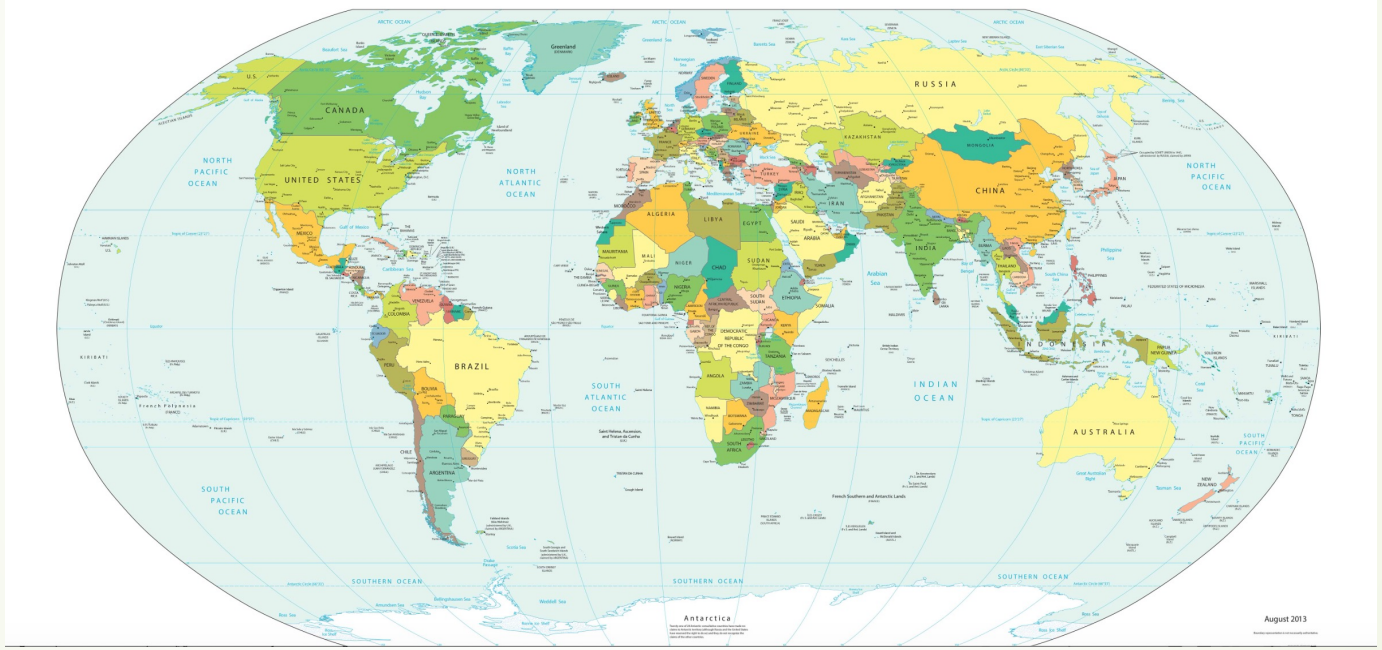
BMS Programme IIMK- Sem III

WORLD AND INDIAN HISTORY



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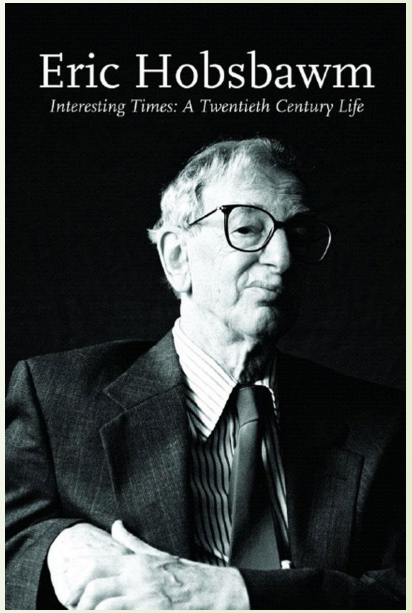
Lecture -1

WHY STUDY HISTORY?
Relevance, Impact and Significance

Readings:

E. J. Hobsbawm, "The Social Function of the Past: Some Questions" (1972)

E. J. Hobsbawm, *On History* (1997), Chapter 3: "What Can History Tell Us About Contemporary Society?"



Learning objectives:

- What does Hobsbawm mean by the **social function of the past**?
- Distinguish between the past as **pattern**, and past as **model**, and past as **historical process**.
- How societies use the past to defend continuity and/ or justify change
- What can history tell us about contemporary society?
- Strengths and limits of historical thinking

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wq8Wu1erCFU

Why Hobsbawm matters?

- One of the most influential historians of the twentieth century
- Associated with Marxist historiography, and ,one of the sharpest thinkers about the broader uses of history in modern societies
- He wrote about class, nationalism, capitalism, revolution, empire, modernity
- Interest in the past is organised into meaning –especially useful for learning about historiography and method
- His writing facilitates in understanding how facts, memories, traditions and narratives are socially mobilised.

Core Argument: “Social Functions of the Past,” 1972

- Hobsbawm argues that the past is a **permanent dimension of human consciousness** – central claim of the essay. In other words, every society relates to a past in some form. No human group lives in a purely present-tense condition

- The real issue for historians is not simply that societies have a past. The issue is **how they use it**. The past can become a source of authority, a moral guide, a political weapon, a marker of identity, or a framework for understanding change

- the historian's problem is to analyse the nature of this **"sense of the past"** in society and to trace its transformations. It leads to Hobsbawm’s thinking about historical consciousness

- **The past is not just inherited; it is socially organized and functionally used.**

The past as pattern

- Past functions as a **pattern for the present -** inherited ways are treated as norms
- the present is expected to reproduce what earlier generations did [customs, ancestral authority, scared texts, old law]
- History is not mainly a story of development. It is a reservoir of precedent and legitimacy
- social arrangements in which the past functions as a stabilizing norm —family structures, village customs, religious law, or inherited land rights

Tradition and change

- Traditional societies are not static. The idea of traditional societies as unchanging is a myth
- Change does happen in such societies – they are often absorbed in ways that do not openly challenge the authority of tradition
- That means change may be:
  - gradual,
  - concealed,
  - renamed,
  - or absorbed into inherited forms
- **Tradition is often strong not because it blocks all change, but because it can absorb change without seeming to surrender its authority**

When the past stops being a pattern

- the past can no longer serve as a direct pattern for the present –it becomes a **model**
- We need to take note of a fundamental difference. A pattern is something one reproduces almost automatically. A model is something one consciously invokes, selects, interprets, and adapts
- One of Hobsbawm's most important historical insights: **the moment a society starts loudly calling for restoration is often the moment when continuity has already broken down**
- Thus, the past moves from being lived tradition to being conscious reference point

Restoration and Invention

- Hobsbawm is sceptical of the language of restoration mainly because it is rarely literal, but subject to selection, reconstruction, or reinvention of what is thought of the past
- He distinguishes between **effective restoration** and **symbolic restoration**
- Effective restoration tries to re-establish actual practices, institutions, or structures
- Symbolic restoration, by contrast, is more about recovering emotional, political, or cultural meaning
- Example: A rebuilt monument, a revived ceremony, or a claim to "ancient freedom" may have enormous symbolic power without literally restoring the social world from which it came
- Interpretation required to assess **innovations claiming the authority of antiquity**

The past as fabrication

- If the past invoked becomes remote enough, it may turn into an artifact, or even, fabrication
- A society may invoke the past that is weakly connected to historical reality
- the past is **politically useful** precisely because it can be selectively organized into a story that legitimizes the present
- **Traditions** may be recent, even constructed, but they can still be powerful because they claim continuity with something older
- **invented pasts can have very real effects**

Innovation, progress and modernity

- The question is no longer how to preserve continuity, but how to make sense of **constant change**
- in modern culture, words like "new" and "revolutionary" often acquire positive value. Novelty itself begins to suggest improvement
- people often accept technological innovation more easily than social or moral innovation
- Modernity is not one simple embrace of the new –it produces enthusiasm in some areas and anxiety in others
- once innovation becomes normal, the past can no longer function simply as a stable precedent

The past as process

- The past becomes useful in a new form: as **process**
- Historical consciousness becomes a story of development, transformation, evolution, and becoming
- Even societies that pride themselves on innovation remain deeply historical
- Hobsbawm puts this almost paradoxically: the more change dominates social life, the more important history becomes as an analytical tool

Genealogy, Identity, and Legitimacy

- Genealogy means not just family trees, but broader efforts by groups to locate themselves in a lineage
- Genealogy provides:
  - continuity,
  - emotional depth,
  - legitimacy,
  - prestige,
  - and often compensation for insecurity
- New nations, new elites, revolutionary movements, and rising social groups often search for heroic predecessors. They want ancestors, even symbolic ones
- Why do modern groups that claim to be creating something new still need to link themselves to older examples?
- Points to consider: Think about how political parties, social movements, or nation-states constantly build lineages for themselves

Chronology and historical thinking

- For modern historians, chronology is essential. We care about sequence, dating, duration, and anachronism. We assume that historical understanding requires placing events in time and tracing directional change

- But Hobsbawm suggests that not all uses of the past work like this. In some settings, the moral, symbolic, or exemplary value of a story may matter more than its precise chronological placement

- The distinction helps us separate:
  - **history** as disciplined temporal reconstruction,
  - **memory** as social remembrance
  - and **myth** as meaning-bearing narrative

- For Hobsbawm, modern historical consciousness is especially bound to chronology because it assumes that history is about **directional transformation**

Transition to *On History* (1997)

- Here, Hobsbawm asks how historians can contribute to understanding the present. To connect with his previous writing (1972), Hobsbawm also argues that the present itself cannot be understood without historical depth. The movement here is from **the social uses of the past** to **the explanatory uses of history.** This is why the two texts belong together. The first is about historical consciousness in society. The second is about the historian's role in interpreting contemporary life
  - one text studies the **social function** of historical consciousness; how societies **live with** the past
  - the other studies the **analytical function** of historical explanation; how historians **think with** the past

- In Chapter 3 of *On History*, Hobsbawm argues that history helps us understand contemporary society by placing it in sequence, by showing its formation, and by identifying long-term processes that are invisible if we look only at the present moment

- This means history can help us:
  - contextualize present institutions,
  - distinguish continuity from rupture,
  - identify what is actually new,
  - and expose false assumptions about novelty

- Hobsbawm sees history as an instrument of **demystification**. It does not predict the future, but it helps us understand how the present was made

What history can and cannot do

- **What can history do?**

It can show the roots of present institutions. It can uncover the historical construction of nations, identities, and traditions. It can reveal that many supposed novelties are actually part of longer developments. And it can help us distinguish genuine rupture from recycled rhetoric.

- **What can history not do?**

It cannot provide mechanical lessons. It cannot tell us exactly what will happen next. It cannot serve as a substitute for political judgment. And it cannot deliver a ready-made program for action.

- This balance is one of the strongest things about Hobsbawm. He gives history a serious public role without turning it into prophecy or moral preaching

Hobsbawm’s contribution in history

- **Hobsbawm's real contribution is to show that history is not only about the past. It is about the ongoing relationship between past and present. Societies use the past to justify themselves, and historians use the past to explain how those societies came to be what they are. That is why history remains indispensable to public life and intellectual inquiry.**

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS:

1. why do societies appeal to the past most loudly in moments of crisis or change?

2. Is nationalism possible without selective history?

3. Does modern society really break from the past, or does it simply reorganize the past in new ways?

Information on Reading History

- Why should we read History?

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rCrASZ2zd8c

- Timeline of World History

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=__BaaMfiD0Q